

Introduction to AJAX

1.1 History of AJAX

Ajax is a concept — a way of making the web more interactive, and as such was never really created or introduced. In fact, the concept existed much before it became popular. However, the term was coined in 2005, by Jesse James Garrett, founder of Adaptive Path.

With the introduction of the `iframe` element in HTML by Internet Explorer in 1996, web developers can now asynchronously load another web page in a section of a currently loaded page. By using an `iframe` with zero dimensions, you could use an `iframe` to load content from another page, extract the relevant parts and inject it into your own page, all in the background.

In 1999, the new XMLHttpRequest ActiveX control was developed by Microsoft for Internet Explorer. The new object can asynchronously load pages, from any web site as desired by the developer. As of now, this is available in all major browsers such as Firefox, Safari and Opera.

In 2006, this control was standardised by the world wide web consortium (W3C), in a draft specification. As a result, once finalised, any new browser that plans to follow web standards will have to support this object.

1.2 Setting it up

JavaScript, XML and HTML are pure text formats, and the only programming tool you really need is a text editor. If you prefer manual coding, you should either prefer Notepad++, or a pure text editor.